



Fast Fashion

How can clothes be so cheap?

A five-dollar T-shirt looks cheap. But somebody, or something, pays the rest.



Listen to the article

Scan the QR code or visit the link.



Cheap clothes wear out quickly and end up on big piles of waste.

WARM-UP

Talk about the questions with a partner.

1. When did you last buy clothes? What did you buy?
2. What is more important: price, quality or style?

USEFUL LANGUAGE

Last month I bought...
For me,... is more important.

A new T-shirt for the price of a cup of coffee. It sounds like a very good deal. In fast-fashion shops, new clothes arrive almost every week, and the prices are very low. But that five-dollar shirt has another cost, and it is not on the price tag.

Fast fashion means clothes that are designed, made and sold very quickly. To keep the price low, a **factory** must work fast and pay small wages. The cloth is cheap, so the **quality** is low. A shirt can lose its shape after five washes, and then it does not **last** another season.

The numbers are surprising. One cotton T-shirt can use about 2,700 liters of water. That is enough drinking water for one person for three years. And every second, somewhere in the world, a truck full of old clothes is burned or buried. Fashion is now one of the dirtiest industries on the planet.

But this can change. More people now buy **second-hand** clothes, or repair the clothes they already have. Some people ask a **brand** a simple question: who made this, and were they paid fairly? Ten shirts you love can be better than a hundred that fall apart.

If a T-shirt costs only five dollars, who is paying the rest?

VOCABULARY

A. Match the words (1–5) with the meanings (A–E).

- | | |
|---------------------|---|
| 1. brand ____ | A. not new; someone used it before |
| 2. quality ____ | B. a building where people make things |
| 3. last ____ | C. to stay good for a long time |
| 4. factory ____ | D. the name of a company that makes something |
| 5. second-hand ____ | E. how good or bad something is |

TRUE OR FALSE

Read the sentences. Circle T (True) or F (False).

- | | | |
|--|---|---|
| 1. A new T-shirt can cost the same as a cup of coffee. | T | F |
| 2. One cotton T-shirt can use about 2,700 liters of water. | T | F |
| 3. Fast-fashion clothes are made to last for many years. | T | F |
| 4. The article says nobody can change this problem. | T | F |
| 5. Some people buy second-hand clothes or repair old ones. | T | F |

DISCUSSION

USEFUL LANGUAGE I think... · For me... · because... · It depends.

- 1 Do you buy clothes often? Why do you buy something new?
- 2 Do you ever buy second-hand clothes? How do you feel about them?
- 3 Why do people buy clothes they do not really need?
- 4 Whose problem is fast fashion: the shops, or the shoppers?
- 5 Ten good shirts or a hundred cheap ones? Which do you choose?



01 CRITICAL THINKING

THE PRICE TEST

Five white T-shirts. The same shirt. Only the price and the story are different.

Choose alone first. Mark every shirt **BUY**, **NOT SURE** or **NO**. Then compare in your group.

PRICE	WHAT YOU KNOW ABOUT IT	BUY	NOT SURE	NO
\$4	Fast fashion, new styles every week. Nobody will tell you where it was made.	☐	☐	☐
\$0	Your brother does not want it. It is free, but it is not new.	☐	☐	☐
\$8	Second-hand, from an app. A stranger wore it twice.	☐	☐	☐
\$28	Organic cotton, much less water. It costs more, but it lasts for years.	☐	☐	☐
\$45	Fair trade. You can read what the workers were paid.	☐	☐	☐

YOUR NUMBER The most you would really pay: \$_____ Your group's highest: \$_____

- DISCUSS**
- 1 Is your number what you believe, or what you can pay?
 - 2 Compare with another group. Would you pay more if the label named the factory?

02 LANGUAGE IN CONTEXT

USE THE LANGUAGE

Complete the sentences with a word from the box.

factory brand last second-hand quality

- 1 This jacket is very good _____.
- 2 My shoes only _____ for six months.
- 3 She bought a _____ coat at a very low price.
- 4 My uncle works in a shoe _____.
- 5 That _____ is very popular with young people.

03 SPEAKING CHALLENGE

ROLE • TASK • PRESENT

Work in small groups. Follow the three steps.

ROLE You design clothes for a big shop. People say your clothes are too cheap.

TASK Choose two changes for your shop. Decide who pays for each one.

PRESENT Tell the class your two changes and say why they are good.

USEFUL LANGUAGE

Our first change is... · We can...
This is better because... · We think... should pay.

04 WRITING

YOUR OPINION

Is it better to have a few good clothes or many cheap ones?

Write 60–100 words. Use words from the article.

USEFUL LANGUAGE

I think it is better to... · The first reason is... · For example,... · But... · So I think...
